

A STEALTH VIRUS
A healthcare worker collects a swab sample for Covid testing in New Delhi

anything to do with the virus at all. "I believed my weakness was due to weight gain during the lockdown, but one night I found my hands shaking simply from the exertion of putting a plate of rice into the microwave. I knew something was wrong," says the 43-year-old. A study of 372 people from 56 countries, published in the journal *EClinicalMedicine* in July 2021, identified 203 symptoms in 10 organ systems, of which 66 were tracked for seven months. The most common symptoms were fatigue, post-exertional malaise and cognitive dysfunction. It also listed symptoms that previously would never have been associated with Covid—visual hallucinations, tremors, itchy skin, changes in menstrual cycles, sexual dysfunction, heart palpitations, bladder control issues, shingles, memory loss, blurred vision, diarrhoea and tinnitus.

Long Covid manifests in a wide variety of symptoms and there is **no accurate set of markers to predict who will get what symptom and when**

"Every 'wave' of Covid has also brought with it a different symptom," says Dr Farah Ingale, an internal medicine specialist at Fortis Hiranandani Hospital, Mumbai. A study by Apollo Hospitals, Delhi, found that instances of Long Covid had increased after the second wave as compared to the first. "The Omicron wave had its own unique set of post-disease complications. Most of my patients reported chronic fatigue even weeks after recovery. This wasn't the case with Alpha or Delta where we saw more problems with respira-